What is data?

You check your phone and see a mobile money transfer of `$25`, a weather app showing `32°C`, and a message from school about your attendance. Each of those is a piece of data — a small fact about something that happened. Before you analyze data, build dashboards, or choose a career in data, you need a clear answer to a simple question: **what is data?**

> BY THE END — You can explain what data is, and tell **data**, **information** and **insight** apart.

Data: raw facts about the world

Data is a collection of facts, measurements, or observations about the world. On its own, data usually does not tell a full story. It is the raw material we use to understand what is happening.

- `$25` — a mobile money transfer amount
- `$2.50 per kg` — the market price of rice
- `present` — a student's attendance record
- `$49.99` — a product price
- `32°C` — a temperature reading

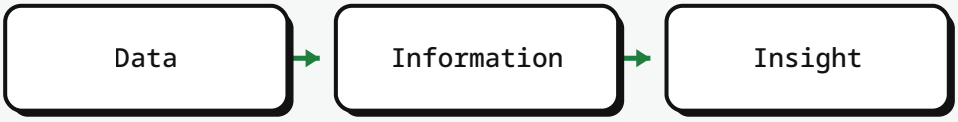
Each example is a single fact. By itself, it may not mean much. But when we collect many facts together, patterns start to appear.

Data vs information vs insight

These three terms are related, but they are not the same. The difference between them is, more or less, the whole job.

TERM	MEANING	EXAMPLE
Data	Raw facts	Sales were `$1,200`, `$980` and `$1,450` on three days
Information	Data organized to answer a basic question	Sales increased from Monday to Wednesday
Insight	A useful conclusion that can guide action	Promotions on Wednesday may be driving higher sales

PLATE I — FROM FACTS TO A DECISION



raw facts become a conclusion you can act on

Each step throws information away and adds meaning. You cannot skip one: an insight with no data underneath it is just an opinion.

Think of it like cooking.

DATA	INFORMATION	INSIGHT
The ingredients, before anyone has decided what to make.	A prepared meal you can actually understand.	Knowing what to cook next time, based on what people liked.

In data work, your goal is to move from raw data toward meaningful insight.

Where you see data every day

Data is not only found in spreadsheets or databases. You create and use data constantly:

- Mobile money transactions and bank transfers
- School grades and attendance records
- Market prices at a local shop
- Likes and comments on social media
- Steps tracked by a fitness app
- Weather forecasts

Businesses, schools, hospitals and governments all rely on data to make decisions. That is why data skills are valuable across many industries.

Key terms

`Data`	Raw facts, measurements, or observations
`Information`	Data that has been organized to convey meaning
`Insight`	A meaningful conclusion, supported by data, that helps guide a decision